



DELHI | Purple Politics

Bt brinjal is the new buzzword in the UPA. Union Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh's recent announcement of a moratorium on the introduction of the genetically modified Bt brinjal has at least three of his ministerial colleagues speaking out in favour of science and technology. Sharad Pawar, Prithviraj Chavan and Kapil Sibal all cite the recommendations of the Genetic Engineering Approval Committee in October last year that allowed the commercial release of Bt brinjal, pronouncing it safe for human consumption. Arguing in its favour, Minister of State for Science and Technology Chavan says, "As far as science is concerned, it is safe." Agriculture Minister Pawar agrees, claiming that while there may be initial constraints but it will prove to be an advantage in the long run for the country. An interesting sideshow of this controversy is this rare moment of bonhomie that has both Maharashtra leaders on the same page for once. Ramesh has been traversing seven states, meeting green activists and farmers' lobbies and thinks caution is the best form of political prudence. He is backed by 10 chief ministers and the Congress party. Playing to both sides, Ramesh adds, "My decision is responsible both to science and to society." For now, Bt brinjals are clearly off the Cabinet table and Pawar will have to look for other means to meet his food security goals.

by Priya Sahgal

**A PROTESTER
GARLANDS
RAMESH WITH
BRINJALS IN
HYDERABAD**

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ministers
have spoken
in favour of
science in the
Bt brinjal
controversy:
Sharad
Pawar, Kapil
Sibal and
Prithviraj
Chavan.